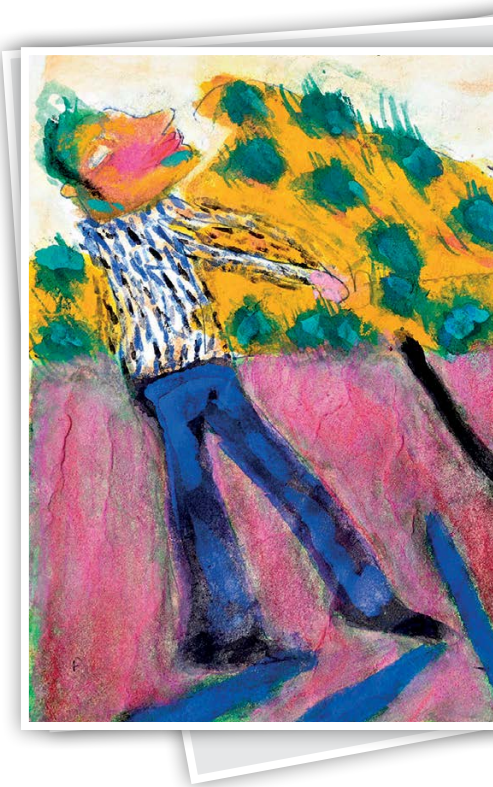


In 2002, Amit Ambalal, one of the pre-eminent figurative artists of the country, produced a gouache painting called 'Jala-Krida' ('jala' is water, 'krida' is play), where a lone swimmer is oblivious to the presence of an alligator sidling up to him in the water. The swimmer's carefree state of mind is depicted through a burst of yellow oleanders around him. The painting has signature Ambalal traits: irony, humour, a certain expansive beauty and a fondness for animal metaphors. As part of his ongoing Delhi exhibition *In the Garden of Sumeru* (at Gallery Espace from January 23 to March 1), the veteran artist has produced another painting with the name 'Jala-Krida' (watercolour on paper, 12.5 x 16 inches), also an underwater scene, this time featuring an elephant alongside turtles and herons. The exhibition includes over 30 paintings by Ambalal in the past two years, mostly watercolours and acrylic-on-canvas works.

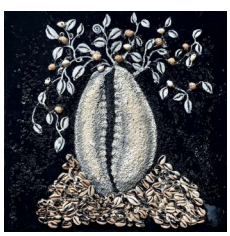
"I really like this word, 'Jala-Krida'. 'Krida' as you know conveys a sense of play," says Ambalal. "This goes back to my interest in the Nathdwara school of paintings, where there are a number of scenes depicting Krishna playing in the water with the gopis." In the new 'Jala-Krida', the elephant is all but submerged, struggling to keep his head above the water. A turtle floats serenely underneath, near the elephant's feet. "Somebody told me once that one should know one's area," says Ambalal. "The elephant is struggling because the water is not his natural domain."

The aforementioned interest in the Nathdwara paintings has been a career-spanning thread in the artist's body of work. It is a topic he has invested considerable time and effort into. In 1987, he published a book called *Krishna as Shrinathji: Rajasthani Paintings from Nathdvara*. The concept of 'lila' ('divine play') as depicted in the context of Lord Krishna made a deep impression on the artist. Ambalal was born into a mercantile Gujarati family, and his father was fond of spending time with artists, musicians, architects et al. Thanks to the artists Jayant Desai and Chhaganlal Jadav (both of whom would visit the house to teach Ambalal's mother and his sisters), the young Ambalal was exposed to Nandalal Bose and the Bengal School, spending his time going through catalogues and art journals. During his early years as an artist in the 1960s, he even tried creating watercolour works with im-



# Cosmic Connections

**In her latest exhibition, artist Jayasri Burman explores themes like the power of femininity, mythology and ecology**



Left, 'Weeping Grace 11' (watercolour, pen and ink); top, 'Oceans Whisperers' (mixed media); facing page, 'Weeping Grace 8' (pen and ink, charcoal, watercolour on paper)

Jayasri Burman's solo show *The Whisper of Water, The Song of Stars* is an ongoing show at Art Alive Gallery in New Delhi but its seeds were sown when she visited Puri as an eight-year-old. "My siblings and I played in the sand and collected shells and cowries. At home, I would wash them and deeply inhale their smell," says the 64-year-old artist, who has used shells and cowries—either painted on canvas or real ones from her collection over the years—to celebrate oceans, fertility and natural beauty in her works.

Memories of the artist's childhood spent in Kolkata, her